

This is how our rental property in New York is set up. The home has both a top and bottom apartment with the exact same floor plan, but the top unit includes an additional finished attic that adds extra square footage to the space. Logically, it rents for more than the bottom one.

The type of upgrades and specific part of the complex will be your deciding factor in payments, but you could shave anywhere from \$10-\$100 off your monthly rent simply by asking if there's an alternative option.

READER TIP:

At our current complex, I purposely chose the UN-upgraded unit as it is all carpet and tile with NO hardwood/laminate. We have dogs and I don't want to get dinged on move-out due to scratches in the flooring from their paws. The entire rest of our unit is super nice and we love the complex. By choosing the non-upgraded unit, I save \$30/mo on my rent and the location of our unit within the complex saves us another \$10.

—Mary, GA

4. OFFER YOUR ASSISTANCE

All landlords have projects they need to get done around the property, and it never hurts to ask how you can help in exchange for a discount on rent.

Sometimes it's a one-time repair, while others require daily or weekly maintenance. As long as you're a hard worker and willing to learn, many property owners would jump at the chance for extra help. Some of the most common tasks to outsource are yardwork, painting, plumbing, or just keeping an eye on things.

If you do take an occasional odd job, talk beforehand with your landlord to nail down how payment will work. Will it be strictly reimbursement based, or per project? Will they subtract the amount from rent, or pay you via cash or check? It's good to have an agreement like this in writing to protect both